



FOREWORD

When I was a boy, I would visit the local public library and spend as long as I was allowed looking at science and reference books. The books that especially enthralled me were the forerunners of this book. Packed with colour diagrams, images of exotic species, and faraway places coupled with informative text, they were the siren call for a lifetime of studying and teaching. The natural world around me was then an unknown entity and I wanted to learn about all of it. It is a very human desire to learn, but nobody knows which bit of biology they will be most attracted to and I went on to pick the largest and most diverse animal group of all. If I were to live a lifetime of lifetimes, I would never know everything there is to know about insects.

No book could ever be a comprehensive study of Earth's extant life forms, which incidentally comprise only one per cent of those that have ever lived. For that you would need a library of hefty tomes. What you have in your hands is much more serviceable. It is a clear road map to guide you on a journey that will take you from the steaming forests of the tropics to the freezing cold of the polar regions, and from mountain peaks to the depths of the ocean. It is an abridged exploration of the products of a couple of billion years of evolution that will show you some of the several million ways of living on Earth.

It is relatively easy to write screeds of detailed information on any topic you care to name, but this approach is not going to be of use to anyone other than experts and it is unlikely to encourage anyone else to study the living world. No, the real skill and the very purpose of this book is to distil a vast body of natural history knowledge amassed by countless researchers to provide an authoritative yet accessible account.

There may come a time in the distant future when we are able to venture elsewhere in our galaxy and beyond. Will we find extraterrestrial life on a far distant rocky planet and if so, will it be simple, single-celled organisms or complex creatures to rival humans or humpbacked whales? To imagine that in the vastness of the Cosmos, our inconsequential planet is the single, solitary place where life has evolved – an unbelievable fluke of stellar serendipity – seems vanishingly improbable. What is certain is that we inhabit a planet of staggering complexity and breathtaking beauty and one that is constantly changing. What we must realize, and quickly, is that we have no dominion over it but are simply part of an immense community of interdependent species.

Newcomers to natural history will find themselves engrossed and even specialists, steeped in the minutiae of one tiny part of the tree of life, will value the majestically broad sweep of this meticulously researched volume. If I could have my life all over again, I'd start by reading this.

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